

History & Folklore A basket of chervil seeds was one of the items found in Tutankhamun's tomb. The herb is traditionally used as a "spring tonic" in central Europe. Chervil is aromatic and is used extensively in cooking.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Chervil is a good remedy for settling the digestion. It is also used to "purify the blood" and to help lower blood pressure, as well as being considered a diuretic. Juice from the fresh plant is applied to various skin conditions, including wounds, eczema, and abscesses.

Aphanes arvensis (Rosaceae) Parsley Piert

Description Prostrate, hairy annual growing to 4 in (10 cm). Has small wedge-shaped leaves and tiny green flowers in tufts.

Habitat & Cultivation Parsley piert is native to Europe, North Africa, and North America. It grows to an altitude of 1,600 ft (500 m), thriving in dry sites, including the top of walls. The herb is harvested when in flower in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Parsley piert contains tannins.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Astringent, diuretic, and demulcent, parsley piert is used to treat kidney and bladder problems, especially kidney stones. It is also frequently used in the treatment of bladder stones (gravel), which cause pain and irritation and obstruct urine flow. Best taken in an infusion, the herb is also a useful remedy for cystitis and recurrent urinary infections.

Aralia racemosa (Araliaceae) American Spikenard

Description Aromatic perennial bush growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has thick fleshy roots, large leathery leaves, small greenish-white flowers, and red or purple berries.

Habitat & Cultivation American spikenard is native to North America. The root is unearthed in summer or autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents American spikenard contains a volatile oil, tannins, and diterpene acids.

History & Folklore The Cherokee made a tea for backache from American spikenard, and the cure was later adopted by New World settlers. The Shawnee used it for flatulence, coughs, asthma, and breast pain; the Menominee as a cure for blood poisoning. The plant was included in the *US National Formulary* from 1916 to 1965.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Many of American spikenard's current uses come directly from Native American precedents. The herb

encourages sweating, is stimulant, and detoxifying. It is taken for rheumatism, asthma, and coughs. Applied externally as a poultice, the herb is used to treat a number of different skin conditions, including eczema.

Related Species Wild sarsaparilla (*A. nudicaulis*) is a North American relative used medicinally in much the same way as American spikenard. The leaves and stalks of two East Asian *Aralia*, *A. chinensis* and *A. cordata*, are eaten as vegetables.

Cautions Do not take during pregnancy.

Arbutus unedo (Ericaceae) Strawberry Tree

Description Evergreen shrub growing to 20 ft (6 m). Has an upright stem with reddish bark, leathery serrated leaves, white or pink bell-shaped flowers, and round warty red fruit resembling strawberries.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Mediterranean coasts, strawberry tree also grows in western Ireland, Australia, and Africa. The leaves are gathered in late summer and the fruit in autumn.

Parts Used Leaves, fruit.

Constituents Strawberry tree contains up to 2.7% arbutin, methylarbutin, and other hydroquinones, a bitter principle, and tannins. Arbutin is powerfully antiseptic in the urinary system.

History & Folklore The fruit of strawberry tree is used in preserves, but it is not palatable fresh. The Latin *unedo* comes from *un ede*, meaning "[only] one I eat."



Strawberry tree's leaves and fruit are astringent and antiseptic.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Strawberry tree is valued as an astringent and antiseptic herb. Its antiseptic action within the urinary tract makes it a useful remedy for treating cystitis and urethritis. Strawberry tree's astringent effect has been put to use in the treatment of diarrhea and dysentery.

Cautions Do not take during pregnancy or if suffering from kidney disease.

Arctostaphylos uva-ursi (Ericaceae) Uva-ursi, Bearberry

Description Low-lying evergreen shrub growing to 20 in (50 cm). Has long trailing stems, dark green leaves that are glossy on the upper side, bell-shaped pink flowers, and small glossy red berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Uva-ursi is native to Europe, and naturalized throughout the northern hemisphere up to the Arctic. It grows in damp conditions in undergrowth, heathland, and grassland. The leaves are gathered in autumn.

Parts Used Leaves, berries.

Constituents The leaves of uva-ursi contain hydroquinones (mainly arbutin, up to 17%), tannins (up to 15%), phenolic glycosides, and flavonoids. Arbutin and other hydroquinones have an antiseptic effect in the urinary tract.

History & Folklore The name uva-ursi means "bear's grape" in Latin. Bears are fond of the fruit. The plant is first documented in *The Physicians of Myddfai*, a 13th-century Welsh herbal text.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Uva-ursi is one of the best natural urinary antiseptics. It has been used extensively in herbal medicine to disinfect and astringe the urinary tract in cases of acute and chronic cystitis and urethritis. However, it is not a suitable remedy if there is a simultaneous infection of the kidneys.

Research Experiments have shown that uva-ursi extracts have an antibacterial effect. This action is thought to be stronger in alkaline urine—thus the efficacy of uva-ursi is likely to increase if it is taken in combination with a vegetable-based diet.

Cautions Do not take during pregnancy or with kidney disease. Unsuitable for children under 12. It is generally advisable to take uva-ursi for no more than 7–10 days at a time.

Arenaria rubra (Carophyllaceae) Sandwort, Sand Spurrey

Description Herbaceous, low-growing, sticky, and hairy annual. Has small thin leaves and pale pink flowers growing to ¼ in (6 mm) across.